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FireDistinguishers



Congress 201: An Introduction to Committees

Effortpost

Introduction

[It's been 84 years.](#) (It's been 3 years.) Remember when I said I'd be dropping this on Friday? Another lie. Turns out that law school takes up a lot of your time. But I promised a post about committees in my very second piece of this series, and I'm **finally** here to deliver.

Committees. The Europeans love them. The Congressmen want to be on them. But does anyone understand them? These incredible groups have led to some of the greatest moments in Congressional history, especially recently.

Where else could you go to hear Matt Gaetz [poorly quoting the Book of Matthew to say that Lloyd Austin's hospital quagmire has anything to do with a vaccine mandate?](#)

Where else could you watch Markwayne Mullin [take his ring off like it's the WWE Raw \(now on Netflix\)?](#)

Where else could you possibly see Tom Cotton [kind of admit he thinks all Asian people are Chinese?](#)

Hilarious.

Anyways here's a post about how committees work, and here's the last post of this series: [Part 7](#)

If Congress is so great, why hasn't there been a "Congress 2"?

Unlike other parts of the government, there's no pretense that the Congress is one continuous and everlasting organization (please learn, judicial branch). Instead, we've had 118 "Congresses" in the history of the Republic. They exist for 2 years each, they're usually split into two 1-year sessions (sometimes 3 back in the day), and they're each unique.

Historically, the Congress had a pretty important job. Seriously, read Article 1 Section 8:

"The Congress shall have power to lay and collect taxes, duties, imposts and excises, to pay the debts and provide for the common defense and general welfare of the United States; ...To regulate commerce with foreign nations, and among the several states, and with the Indian tribes; ... To raise and support armies; To provide and maintain a navy; ... And To make all laws which shall be necessary and proper for carrying into execution the foregoing powers, and all other powers vested by this Constitution in the government of the United States, or in any department or officer thereof."

The Framers modeled the power of the legislature after the power of the monarchs of Europe. That's one of the funnier pieces of the whole "voters think the US elects a king every 4 years" thing. **We do elect a king in the United States. We just elect one in pieces, two years at a time.**

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But even still, the first Congress had committees. So what's going on?

Committees in theory (which can only take us so far)

So, imagine it's 1789. You have 59 guys in a room in New York. They have to solve some problem. They can either all sit together and brainstorm and write and try to figure it out while constantly arguing with each other (which is kind of how they fought the British), or they can say "Hey wait, we have like 4 problems to solve right now and they're all time sensitive, [what if we split up?](#)"

So they split up.

7 of them get together and worry about how they're going to run elections, a few of them go worry about rules and procedure, the rest decide to all work on taxes and revenue, and they say "Ok, we'll go make some plans, and then we'll come back to the big group of all of us with the plans, and then we can talk about changing those plans, and then when we can agree on that we can have a final vote on if the plans are good enough to be a law on how we're going to deal with all this shit."

Bing bang boom, that's committees: just a small group in charge of one set of issues that can come back to the whole crowd and say "this is what we figured out."

And in that 1st Congress, it was so small and the government had so few categorical issues (as opposed to sporadic shit that had to get fixed), they could afford to have 4 Committees in the House (Elections, Rules, Ways and Means, and Whole), 1 in the Senate (Whole), and 1 to share between the two (Enrolled Bills).

That was basically all committees were for like 150 years. Every time there was a new category of problem the Congress needed to solve, they'd whip up a new batch of guys to break off and figure out "ok this is what we're doing about this," before bringing it back to the rest of their chamber.

Committee-ment Issues

[Pearl Harbor changed everything](#). Already stretched to the absolute MAX by the Depression and Roosevelt's unprecedented electoral mandate, World War 2 was one of the most impactful things on America's legislature. I still haven't found a good book that explains all the shit that happened in Congress because of this war, but the Committee situation seriously got out of hand. Instead of the cute group of 6 Committees doing their part in exercising those kingly responsibilities, the 79th Congress had **separate committees** for:

- Accounts (H)
- Agriculture (H)
- Agriculture and Forestry (S)
- Appropriations (H)
- Appropriations (S)
- Arrange the Inauguration for President-elect (J)
- Atomic Energy (J)
- Atomic Energy (Select) (S)
- Audit and Control the Contingent Expenses of the Senate (S)

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- Campaign Expenditures Investigation, 1944 (Special) (S)
 - Campaign Expenditures Investigation, 1946 (Special) (S)
 - Census (H)
 - Civil Service (H)
 - Civil Service (S)
 - Civil Service Laws (Special) (S)
 - Claims (H)
 - Claims (S)
 - Coinage, Weights and Measures (H)
 - Commerce (S)
 - Conditions of Indian Tribes (Special) (J)
 - Conservation of Wildlife Resources (Select) (H)
 - Disposition of Executive Papers (H)
 - Disposition of Executive Papers (J)
 - Disposition of Surplus Property (Select) (H)
 - District of Columbia (H)
 - District of Columbia (S)
 - Education (H)
 - Education and Labor (S)
 - Election of the President, Vice President, and Representatives in Congress (H)
 - Elections No.1 (H)
 - Elections No.2 (H)
 - Elections No.3 (H)
 - Enrolled Bills (H)
 - Enrolled Bills (S)
 - Expenditures in Executive Departments (H)
 - Expenditures in Executive Departments (S)
 - Finance (S)
 - Flood Control (H)
 - Foreign Affairs (H)
 - Foreign Relations (S)
 - Immigration (S)
 - Immigration and Naturalization (H)
 - Indian Affairs (H)
 - Indian Affairs (S)
 - Insular Affairs (H)
 - Interoceanic Canals (S)
 - Interstate and Foreign Commerce (H)
 - Interstate Commerce (S)

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- [Investigation of the Pearl Harbor Attack \(J\)](#)
 - [Irrigation and Reclamation \(H\)](#)
 - [Irrigation and Reclamation \(S\)](#)
 - [Judiciary \(H\)](#)
 - [Judiciary \(S\)](#)
 - [Labor \(H\)](#)
 - [Legislative Budget \(J\)](#)
 - [Library \(H\)](#)
 - [Library \(J\)](#)
 - [Library \(S\)](#)
 - [Manufactures \(S\)](#)
 - [Merchant Marine and Fisheries \(H\)](#)
 - [Military Affairs \(H\)](#)
 - [Military Affairs \(S\)](#)
 - [Mines and Mining \(H\)](#)
 - [Mines and Mining \(S\)](#)
 - [Naval Affairs \(H\)](#)
 - [Naval Affairs \(S\)](#)
 - **Organization of Congress (J)** ([that's a surprise tool that can help us later](#))
 - [Organization of Congress \(Select\) \(S\)](#)
 - [Patents \(H\)](#)
 - [Patents \(S\)](#)
 - [Pensions \(H\)](#)
 - [Pensions \(S\)](#)
 - [Petroleum Resources \(Special\) \(S\)](#)
 - [Post Office and Post Roads \(H\)](#)
 - [Post Office and Post Roads \(S\)](#)
 - [Post-War Economic Policy and Planning \(Special\) \(H\)](#)
 - [Post-War Economic Policy and Planning \(Special\) \(S\)](#)
 - [Post-War Military Policy \(Select\) \(H\)](#)
 - [Printing \(H\)](#)
 - [Printing \(J\)](#)
 - [Printing \(S\)](#)
 - [Privileges and Elections \(S\)](#)
 - [Public Buildings and Grounds \(H\)](#)
 - [Public Buildings and Grounds \(S\)](#)
 - [Public Lands \(H\)](#)
 - [Public Lands and Surveys \(S\)](#)
 - [Reduction of Nonessential Federal Expenditures \(J\)](#)

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- Rivers and Harbors (H)
 - Roads (H)
 - Rules (H)
 - Rules (S)
 - Selective Service Deferments (J)
 - Small Business (Select) (H)
 - Small Business Enterprises (Special) (S)
 - Standards of Official Conduct (H)
 - Taxation (J)
 - Territories (H)
 - Territories and Insular Affairs (S)
 - Un-American Activities (H)
 - War Claims (H)
 - Ways and Means (H)
 - Whole (H)
 - Whole (S)
 - Wildlife Resources (Special) (S)
 - Wool Production (Special) (S)
 - World War Veterans' Legislation (S)

Any sane person sees that's too many right? It got so bad that even Congress noticed. So the Joint Committee on the Organization of Congress came in with a bunch of reforms to help make things manageable again. Enter: the [Legislative Reorganization Act of 1946 \(P.L 79-601\)](#), the vehicle to bring the legislature back into line as the primary (but still equal) branch of government, as the framers intended.

The last 80 years prove that didn't fucking work, but the reforms in this thing are largely responsible for the office structure that I went over in part 5 the eventually amended rules around lobbying that people play by which I described in part 6 & 7, and frankly a lot of minor budget considerations covered in part 1 & 2. For today's discussion though, this act created the system of committees and subcommittees that we see to this day, it defined the roles of the standing committees, and it significantly professionalized congressional committee staff.

Committees Today

Alright, here's the meat and potatoes.

Types of Committees

You have different types of Committees:

Standing Committees are permanent, they and their jurisdiction exist in the chamber's rules adopted at the start of every Congress. Their job is to consider legislative changes to issues within their jurisdiction and oversee the agencies tasked with carrying out those legislative matters. Two sets of standing committees have additional responsibilities over the money: the *House Ways and Means* and *Senate Finance* Committees

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Select Committees (sometimes called **Special Committees**) are established by a separate resolution in the chamber, and can be permanent or temporary. They exist because the existing list of standing committees doesn't cover an issue area that a chamber thinks is important. Famous select committees include committees meant to advise but without jurisdiction (the House Select Committee on Energy Independence and Global Warming was advisory, but most of its advice related to things under the jurisdiction of House Appropriations Energy & Water, House Science, House Energy), or often they're meant to investigate but not legislate (the House Special Committee on Un-American Activities Authorized to Investigate Nazi Propaganda and Certain Other Propaganda Activities, the Senate Select Committee on Presidential Campaign Activities, and the House Select Committee on Benghazi famously fell in this camp).

You also have **Joint Committees**, made up of Members of both chambers. Nowadays a lot of joint committees are permanent panels that conduct studies or perform housekeeping tasks between the chambers. The most famous (and usually most important) versions of these, though, are the **Conference Committees**, temporary joint committees formed to resolve differences in Senate- and House-passed versions of a measure.

Exclusivity

This is where things become complicated.

"Political parties suck" - George Washington

And he was absolutely right, but unfortunately they've become completely embedded in the fabric of the Congress.

A sub-level of Congressional rules that I haven't gone over yet are party rules. Sure, the House is partisan and majoritarian (see Part 1), but what does that mean for the individual Member of Congress? Well here's one manifestation of that. Both of the organized parties in both chambers (therefore, 4 groups in total) have their own rules about additional categorizations of committees.

In the House, there are **exclusive** and **non-exclusive** committees that are entirely dictated by party rules (and frankly, party norms). Generally, if a member sits on an exclusive committee, they don't sit on any others, but their party can grant them a waiver. Both the Democratic Caucus and Republican Conference recognize that the House Committee on:

- Appropriations,
- Ways and Means,
- Rules,
- Energy & Commerce, and
- Financial Services

are on their exclusive lists. The rest are non-exclusive. This is a formal thing in Democratic Caucus documents, and a long standing Republican practice, so let's see how the party of old fashioned values keeps that alive as we potentially head into our 3rd speaker in the 118th.

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circumstances, a Senator "shall" serve on two "A" committees, "may" serve on one "B" committee, and don't need to worry about limits on "C" committees. Beyond that, if a party decides one of the "A" committees is going to be a "Super A" for them, then Senators who conference with that party can only serve on that "Super A" and no other "Super A's".

Here are the "C" committees, with no restrictions:

- Ethics
- Indian Affairs
- Joint on Taxation
- Joint on the Library
- Joint on Printing

Here are the "B" committees, where the Senators can join either just one, or none at all:

- Budget
- Rules & Administration
- Veterans' Affairs
- Small Business
- Aging
- Joint Economic

And here are the "A" Committees, where every Senator must serve on exactly two:

- Agriculture, Nutrition, and Forestry
- Appropriations
- Armed Services
- Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs
- Commerce, Science, and Transportation
- Energy & Natural Resources
- Environment & Public Works
- Finance
- Foreign Relations
- Homeland Security & Governmental Affairs
- Judiciary
- Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions
- Intelligence

At least based on the last time I read the rules, both the Democrats and the Republicans think *Appropriations*, *Armed Services*, and *Finance* should have "Super A" status, but only the Republicans think *Foreign Relations* should also be a "Super A" committee because go fuck yourself. Also, these rules can either be waived by the party or the chamber depending on whose rules we're playing by.

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And he was absolutely right, but unfortunately they've become completely embedded in the fabric of the Congress.

In both chambers, the parties have additional committees that specifically sort out matters involving their party's positions, rules, and delegation of responsibilities, as opposed to the legislative work of the committees of the chamber itself. Just to give some flavor of a few you have the:

House Democratic Steering and Policy Committee These guys put together the lists of which House Dems are going to serve on which committees, and which of those people will be in a leadership position on that committee (we'll talk more about that later). They also decide on which policies are officially part of the House Democratic policy agenda. Their biggest incentives are: growing the House Dem majority, helping a Dem in the White House, destroying a House Republican majority, and harming a Republican in the White House.

Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee These guys are the official campaign arm of the Democrats in the House. They're completely separate from the Congress, but DCCC leadership sits on the Steering & Policy Committee, mostly to serve as an electoral sanity check on committee assignments and the policy agenda. Even though they're not staffed by congressional staff, they're always chaired by a Democratic Member of the House.

House Democratic Committee on Caucus Procedures Exist to amend the rules you find [here](#).

House Democratic Policy and Communications Committee Take the work that the other House Dem committees here put together and work on messaging them correctly given their audience. DPCC leadership also sits on the Steering & Policy Committee, to make sure they don't make Public Affairs nightmares in the same way as the DCCC tries to avoid electoral nightmares.

House Republican Steering Committee These guys put together lists of which House Republicans are going to serve on which committees, and which of those people will be in that committee's leadership. Again, they exist here to put people in the right place so they can help the GOP and hurt the Dems.

House Republican Committee on Policy These guys holistically look at what House Republicans are proposing in legislation, and either change it to be more in favor of the House Republican agenda, promote it if it's already in favor of the House Republican agenda, or adopt it as part of the House Republican agenda if they think "hey, we should all be doing that." Recently they've spent a lot of time focused on shitting on what the Democrats are doing, and sometimes shitting on what the Democrats have nothing to do with at all but still blaming them anyway.

National Republican Congressional Committee Same as the DCCC, but for House Republicans.

Senate Democratic Policy & Communications Committee A research committee that makes recommendations on what Senate democrats should adopt as policies and how they should communicate them, but much less powerful than its House counterparts. Still though, goals are always to help the Dems and hurt the GOP, but with particular focus on matters beyond the Senate.

Senate Democratic Steering & Outreach Committee Another steering committee to decide who's on which committee and who's in charge, but this time for Senate Dems.

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Dems, with a much harder job because unlike the DCCC, Senate elections are more expensive and happen less often (and they can get inconsistent if somebody retires before their class of Senators is up for reelection).

Senate Republican Policy Committee You know what's crazy? I can't tell you exactly what these guys do. The Senate Republican Conference rules are hidden behind party lines on TrunkLine (the Senate Republican intranet). I can find the 117th's rules, but the 118th? Nowhere public. And I'm not that pressed to ask one of my exes in a Republican office to send them my way.

But generally speaking they pick the Republican party line in the Senate. Especially as it pertains to sticking it to the Dems.

Senate Republican Committee on Committees A steering committee in everything but name. They pick who goes where and who goes where with the burden of leadership, as long as that "who" is a Senate Republican. These are the dickheads that put Rand Paul on HSGAC to spite Gary Peters, the Democratic party, and lovers of good governance everywhere, and I'll never forgive them for it.

National Republican Senatorial Committee Take a guess.

So, in addition to their official duties in running the country, Senators and Representatives (and some of their staff) spend a lot of time also doing their part to run their party. They work on assigning people to the right legislative committee, considering what the party line is and trying to make sure their personal and parochial interests align with that party line, and making sure they and more people like them can get elected to further all those objectives (and, implicitly, making sure fewer people like the guys on the other side of the aisle get elected too).

"But Firedistinguishers," I hear you calling out from your wine caves, "this seems like so much work. And since there's a finite number of legislators (itself a contentious issue), doesn't all this work come on top of the tasks of helping their constituents and running their country that they were elected to do in the first place?"

Yeah. It's a serious effort. On the House side especially, where the parties are much more powerfully involved, you hear about the young members who get a chance to join one of these party committees never leaving the Capitol Office Complex for weeks on end so they (and their staff) can get all this work done.

"But come on Firedistinguishers," you reply, as you shovel another wad of dark money into the engines of the political machines you tend, "does the added work not entirely confirm President Washington's prediction that pursuit of maintaining a party coalition 'distract[s] the Public Councils and enfeeble[s] the Public Administration,' especially considering the Rand Paul example and how you describe so much of the work of these extracurricular activities being expressly for the purposes of making sure the other party finds as little success as possible in the same way that President Washington foretold that 'the alternate domination of one faction over another, sharpened by the spirit of revenge, natural to party dissension, which in different ages and countries has perpetrated the most horrid enormities, is itself a frightful despotism. But this leads at length to a more formal and permanent despotism,' which we now see before us as this nation is subject to the oppression of inactivity in the face of glaring issues?!"

Yes.

[Political parties suck.](#)

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[Here's the list of Committees in the Senate](#)

Who's on these things?

Representatives and Senators, of various backgrounds and levels of decency. But how do they get on there? Now *that's* a good question.

Committee assignments are important. They dictate what an individual Member of Congress is going to spend a lot of time working on (or not), and what they'll be known for (or not). There's obviously powerful committees like approps (where you get to decide how the country spends its money, and if you're good at your job direct that money to things that benefit your constituents), or House Rules (read Part 2 if you want to see how cracked these guys can be).

But even if you're on something that has lower legislative output, serving on a committee dictates which hearings you'll be in, which means it dictates where a lot of the potential clips that your campaign might use come from. Even if a committee only marks up like 4 bills that make it to law in a Congress (low number to make a point), the people on the committee will still have hundreds of hours of free campaign material in the form of CSPAN footage of them asking substantive or politically charged questions to witnesses in an open setting to prove they're the champion of **something**.

Lawyers and attention seekers want to be on Judiciary (it's the biggest battleground), border hawks want to be on Homeland (shocking that this one isn't the biggest battleground), "healthcare pls" types want to get on H.E.L.P. (this one SHOULD be a bigger battleground), and decent human beings and one asshole want to be on Indian Affairs (guess who).

So how do you get on one of these things?

In the House

The House needs to elect members of its standing committees within 7 calendar days after the start of a Congress. Of course, like all Congressional Rules, the House can waive this requirement. Usually nowadays they appoint a few members within those 7 days, and then keep adding as time goes on.

House Rule X limits Representatives to serving on two standing committees, and four subcommittees (two on each, three and one sometimes). Again, they can waive these rules.

Some committees in the House have pretty specific requirements on composition. For example, House Budget needs to be comprised of:

- 5 Members from Appropriations
- 5 Members from Ways and Means
- 1 Member from Rules
- 1 Member hand picked by the Majority's leadership, and
- 1 Member hand picked by the Minority's leadership

Democrats

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secret ballot by default, you have to get 10 people to ask for one to get that to happen), before being proposed to the full House Chamber. Here's the breakdown:

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Agriculture	X	
Appropriations	X	
Armed Services	X	
Budget	All but One Member (the Chair is picked by the whole Caucus)	That Last Guy
Education and Labor	X	
Energy and Commerce	X	
Ethics	X	
Financial Services	X	
Foreign Affairs	X	
Homeland Security	X	
House Administration		X
Judiciary	X	
Natural Resources	X	
Oversight and Reform	X	
Rules		X
Science, Space, and Technology	X	
Small Business	X	
Transportation and Infrastructure	X	
Veterans' Affairs	X	
Ways and Means	X	
Special, select, & other committees		X

Republicans

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But hey, another party another chart:

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Agriculture	X	
Appropriations	X	
Armed Services	X	
Budget	All but 1 Member (including the Chair)	That Last Guy (can't be the Chair)
Education and Labor	X	
Energy and Commerce	X	
Ethics	X	
Financial Services	X	
Foreign Affairs	X	
Homeland Security	X	
House Administration		X
Judiciary	X	
Natural Resources	X	
Oversight and Reform	X	
Rules		X
Science, Space, and Technology	X	
Small Business	X	
Transportation and Infrastructure	X	
Veterans' Affairs	X	
Ways and Means	X	
Special, select, & other committees		X

In the Senate

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somebody hates someone in particular), but let's pray to God none of these Senators realize they can do that.

Just like the House, ratios here are a matter of who has the majority and by how much. Sometimes you can't get rid of a compositional requirement like SSCI has, but come on let's get to the real juicy stuff right?

Democrats

Committee assignments up here are all based on recommendations from the Democratic Steering & Outreach Committee, subject to approval by the Conference. A big point of consideration here in the Senate are seniority, member preference, and past service on relevant committees. Unlike in the House which has this weird half-assed "we don't discriminate based on prior work experience, we only consider merit, length of service, degree of commitment to the Democratic agenda, diversity of the Caucus" and all that bs as they go on to totally discriminate based on prior work experience and just toss in some weird picks just to throw people off, the Senate is more like "yeah let's put people where they need to be."

The Steering Committee can't recommend two members from the same state for the same committee unless a waiver is granted by the whole Conference, and like the House these committee appointments *should* reflect the diversity of the Democrats. Pretty notably, freshman members are assigned, whenever possible, to at least one major committee of their choice, but if you ask for a thicker slice than usual you usually have to back it up with something (see: my former Boss' deal to get on the Appropriations Committee as a freshman Senator).

Like we talked about a few paragraphs ago, certain committees (Appropriations, Armed Services, Finance) are "Super A" material, and therefore exclusive, so members may not serve on more than one unless waivers are granted.

Oh and sportsmanship matters here. If a member is removed from a committee due to changes in the majority-minority ratio, they have the first claim to the next available seat on that committee. If a member voluntarily *gives up* their seat on a committee to accommodate another member's request and later wishes to rejoin, they also retain the next available seat on that committee, and their seniority.

Republicans

Couldn't tell you, TrunkLine shit.

Who's in charge?

The two most important (and sometimes the two only important) members of a committee are its chair and its ranking member. Legally, the authority of the committee almost always sits entirely with these two, heavily weighted towards the former of course. I've thrown these terms around a bit, but it's important to just hold that in practice, usually these are the people who actually want to get things done on the committee, they're the ones that most of the committee staff report to, and they have some additional capabilities that just some random member on the committee won't have.

The chair has "control of the dais" (that big desk or series of desks they sit at), meaning they're officially the ones running the show when the committee is convened, and "control of the calendar" which means they decide when the committee convenes and what it's supposed to do with itself when it gets together. They

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The ranking member has control of their party. Sometimes.

Subcommittees

Instead of the old structure where you'd have individual matters appearing before independent committees that may or may not contain overlapping members (and therefore overlapping expertise), with absolutely no accountability to each other, committees today have one additional step-down group in the form of subcommittees.

Their roles? Varied. Always defined in the committee's rules adopted by the chair and ranking member.

Their membership? Varied. Always a smaller subset of members that sit on the full committee.

Their staff? Varied. Some of them have teams of highly independent staff, some of them have people who are dual-hatted between the chair or ranking member's personal office and the committee, and some of them have people who blur the line between the full committee and subcommittee.

Their usefulness? Varied. Entirely depends on what fucking phase of the moon we're in.

Who does the work here?

If you've read Part 5 you know all about personal office staff, but I'm here to say that committees have their own staff too.

Top of the food chain on a committee is the **Committee Staff Director**, who serves in a similar role to a personal office's Chief of Staff. They're usually hand picked by the chair, and they're usually a pretty involved boss, especially if they decide to dual-hat their roles with the job of one of their immediate reports: the **Director of Legislation** (a Committee's equivalent to the personal office's LD) and the **Director of Oversight**.

A quick callout box on Oversight: A big role these committees is that they serve as the fountainhead of the ability for executive departments and agencies to do their jobs. Every agency, therefore, has at least one associated authorizing committee (to give them the legal right to do what they do), an appropriations subcommittee (to fund those activities they have the right to do), and an oversight committee (to check and see if they're doing a good job). I'll explain this more in my next post.

Beneath these 3, you have 3 buckets:

The smallest is usually communications. Unlike personal office press shops, which exist in this limbo of making sure your boss gets reelected while also kind of spitting out facts, committee communications shops mostly stick to the facts plus some political tint. Here you have your **Communications Director**, who is in charge of some **Communications Assistants/Communications Managers/Digital Assistants/Digital Coordinators/Digital Directors**, that all kind of do the same job of writing what the committee is up to, taking and editing video, and spreading that to where it needs to go.

Administrative staff are the lifeblood of actually getting the work done, and they're also usually the most disparate in responsibility. Committee **Staff Assistants** spend their time keeping time during hearings, filling printers, and answering phones. Committee **Clerks** fit in this weird in-between of scheduling and sometimes helping policy staff if they dual-hat as a Legislative Assistant (more on them later). They can very much be the

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offices of the committee's membership. Then you have committee **Parliamentarian(s)**, who are the ones who've sufficiently internalized the chamber, committee, and party rules (if they're on a committee that designates its admin staff to one party, not all of them do, especially in the Senate), to be able to tell the members how to actually go about the activities they're trying to do at the committee level. [Here's a great clip](#) where you can see how even experienced legislators who know some of the rules need to rely on these guys to tell them how to make these things operate. Again, important work at all levels, but it's VERY split.

Finally you have the legislative staff. These people are responsible for writing most of the law. **Subcommittee Staff Directors** are a combination between the full committee's staff director, director of legislation, and director of oversight, leading a small team focused on a particular set of issues within the larger committee's jurisdiction. They lead and liaise with **Professional Staff Members** and **Counsel**, whose roles are IDENTICAL but they get different names because one contingent has a JD and the other does not. These guys are deep knowledge experts about something, and serve either a subcommittee directly or the full committee, and *they're the ones who actually do the work associated with creating legislation and considering oversight*. They worked their way up from a more junior role (like a **Committee Legislative Assistant** who reports to them and might have their own portfolio sometimes), maybe they're coming from an agency full time to oversee the programs they used to be part of, or on detail from an agency or think tank or non profit that's given them the chance to be a **Fellow** (essentially a stand in for any job on this list, but their salary is paid for by an organization outside the Congress; seriously they can be a glorified intern or they can be a career civil servant who you should treat like a staff director in everything but name).

An Inconclusive Conclusion

Turns out you can only post 40,000 characters at a time. So I'm splitting this up into 3 posts. Join us next time when we talk about the work these guys actually do.

↑ 186 ↓ 61 🔔 ↗

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FireDistinguishers OP • 2y ago

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Teh_cliff • 2y ago • Edited 2y ago

This is amazing. Are you doing full time law school?



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how long do the committee staff tend to stay in a committee?

don't they make them a continuous institution type thing?

**FireDistinguishers** **OP** • 2y ago

Honestly it depends. I know a staff director who's been there since 2000, and I know another staff director who's never had the same job for more than 2 years since 2000.

Overall, there's enough change in responsibility (with the majority and minority switching), and personnel (I'd say 60% move every 2 years, to another job, another office, or out of Congress) to warrant there being significant change

**[deleted]** • 2y ago

Couldn't tell you, Tusknet shit.

What is Tusknet. I'm assuming this is revealing my ignorance.

**FireDistinguishers** **OP** • 2y ago

It's the Senate Republican intranet, I know I should've spent more time explaining it considering I brought it up twice but I ran out of room

 9 more replies**marsexpresshydra** • 2y ago

How funny, I was just watching a super long video about appropriations subcommittees last night

**FireDistinguishers** **OP** • 2y ago

slide that link

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Only loosely related, but what do you think are the odds of the Ukraine aid discharge petition going through?

**FireDistinguishers** [OP](#) • 2y ago

Let me say it like this, I'm hopeful I'll be pleasantly surprised

2 more replies

**john_doe_smith1** • 2y ago

HES BACK!!!! Another post, another reason to marvel at the strange evolution of our legislative system.

Only tangentially related, but as neoliberals governmental expert, do you have any advice for someone who would like to intern in Washington?

**FireDistinguishers** [OP](#) • 2y ago

Intern in what capacity? Honestly, if you can swing it, come in the spring or fall, it's so much less competitive (supply issue) and the work you'll do is almost always going to be more substantive (better timing in the leg cycle, usually you'll get a longer term)

5 more replies

**DEEP_STATE_NATE** • 2y ago

What's the democratic equivalent of Tusknet called?

**FireDistinguishers** [OP](#) • 2y ago

I know we have something but I (and all the offices I've worked in) have just used Webster

1 more reply

**spudicrous** • 2y ago

Do you have, or have you heard around the town, any specific solutions to the committee situation? It seems like a bit of a mess, but honestly that is to be expected of any large organization of people with wide-ranging responsibilities and powers.

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Oh man honestly? Reducing the number of committees that members can be on is a huge one, to include the party committees. Frankly, a lot of the issues are campaign reform issues, and changing the way we can use footage of public officials, but even that's more of solving the symptom not the problem. The fact of the matter is that until we find a better way to campaign without sensationalizing the back and forth we see in committee footage right now, there's just no reform possible. Same reason people always say that the classified hearings are so much better since we don't have cameras in the room

+ 4 more replies



sharpshooter42 • 2y ago

Can we also talk about how Republican house committee chair / ranking member term limits are absolutely screwing them over but they are unable to get rid of them?



FireDistinguishers OP • 2y ago

Oh part 3 is ALL about problems with the system



Extreme_Rocks • 2y ago

New FireDistinguishers effortpost



+ 1 more reply



empvespasian • 2y ago

Brilliant effortpost. Seriously appreciate these a lot

[Skip to main content](#)[Find anything](#)[Ask](#)[Log In](#)**TrekkiMonstr** • 2y ago

In the Senate, there are "A," "B," and "C," committees that are set by Senate Rule XXV (thereby preserving some defense against majoritarianism in the superior chamber), but there are also "Super A" committees set by the party conferences (thereby defiling that defense they just fucking set).

Sorry, I'm missing something. How does this defend against majoritarianism?

**FireDistinguishers** [OP](#) • 2y ago

Something being encoded in the rules of the chamber (in this case, the Senate Rules) is always going to be more broadly palatable than something enacted in the party rules, since the parties are these weird vestigial entities that have latched on to the legislature

So when the exclusivity rules are part of Senate chamber rules, not the party rules of the House democrats and republicans (which can change literally whenever, and entrench these institutions into our legislature in the ways I described are harmful to original intent) you have SOME defense against majoritarianism

[+ 2 more replies](#)**MarsOptimusMaximus** • 2y ago

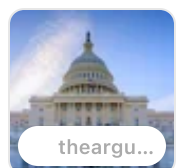
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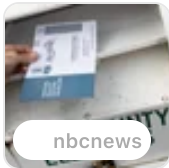
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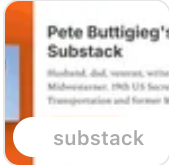
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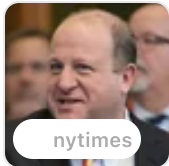
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When you forget free trade can happen:



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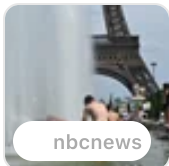
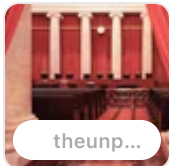
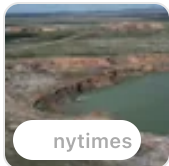
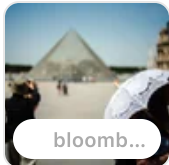
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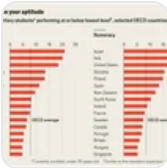
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